

Feeling the Pulse of the Common Man

Chief Minister Digambar Kamat has unobtrusively but firmly been at the helm of his Government in Goa. Undaunted by threats to its stability, Mr Kamat has completed one year of Congress-led rule in Goa. He elaborates on his successes and on his vision for Goa in a freewheeling interview

Can you outline some major developments in the state after completing one year in office?

As ancient wisdom dictates, a journey of a thousand miles begins with the first step. This government has taken several concrete steps in every facet of governance. Goa is the first state in the country to have its own cultural policy. Goa is also the first state to launch a scheme to supply essential commodities at wholesale prices by even mobilizing vans to move around in rural areas. This has helped to keep a check on rising prices. Goa has also finalized its Draft Mining Policy which will be thrown open to the public for objections and suggestions. My government has prepared a Draft Integrated Education Policy which will be deliberated upon and finalized in tune with the Education Vision Document for the state. Furthermore, Educational Estates/Integrated Education complexes will have common playground, auditorium etc. Among other measures, Mobile Health Care Clinics in villages take health care to the doorstep of the people. For the first time in India, a project for screening of new-born babies to detect congenital defects has been launched. We are in tune with the policy of the UPA government at the Centre in which more thrust has been given to Education, Health and Women empowerment as per the 11th Five Year Plan.

How do you visualize the future of Goa?

I visualize Goa as the dream Social Welfare State of the nation, a state that others would like to emulate. During the past year, despite repeated attempts to overthrow my Government, I have stood by my resolve to direct all efforts to turn Goa into a model state, keeping the common man the nucleus of all development activities. For the poor to move ahead, education is a must, and I have tried to make the education system accessible to all. Our government's working model is based on transparency and trust and it is with this model that we will continue to work with in the future.

The recent victory in the trust vote in Parliament has also boosted our confidence. Our Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singhji has shown the courage of his convictions. He has shown his true mettle. Our party President and UPA Chairperson Smt Sonia Gandhiji has always been our guiding light.



Smt. Sonia Gandhi, Hon'ble Chairperson of UPA being greeted by Shri. Digambar Kamat

How do you view the scrapping of SEZs and the Regional Plan 2010?

I have to abide by the will and wishes of the people. Clearly, the small territory of Goa cannot accommodate monolithic projects. We have constituted a Task Force for guiding the preparation of the Regional Plan 2021 for Goa. This Task Force consists of eminent people like Charles Correa and Edgar Ribeiro. It has already submitted an Interim report on the Regional Plan in May this year and a final report on the Draft Regional Plan is expected soon. But without development, Goa will come to a standstill. We are promoting environmentally friendly industries. And within the Government itself, we are enhancing our IT services to harness the true potential of the IT revolution. The 4-laning of highways is already in the offing, and the 6-member committee on the Mopa Airport Project has submitted its report recommending the construction of a new, modern, state-of-the-art international airport at Mopa and the retention of the existing airport at Dabolim with upgradation to international standards and capacity expansion.

You have been particularly interested in Art and Culture.

The recent opening of the Ravindra Bhavan in Margao has plugged a glaring need in these parts for a suitable venue and platform for the performing arts. The Government has also decided to set up such Bhavans in other talukas. The government regularly presents state cultural awards to deserving personalities in the arts.

You are known as the most accessible CM...

I have always been sensitive to the needs of the common man...my house is an open house for people from all walks of life to come and air their grievances and problems. As I said, we believe in the twin principles of Transparency and Trust. And to win the trust of people, you have to identify with them and not just lend a ear to their problem, but act on resolving their issues to their satisfaction.